

STAR CAMPAIGNERS
PM Modi and (right) Rahul Gandhi join other party leaders on the campaign

ANI

the Congress is getting 123 seats. He also proudly points out how 7.7 million listed Congress workers are carrying the party's message to people's homes.

Shivakumar, meanwhile, radiates confidence as he heads in his white Ford Endeavour to the Jakkur aerodrome in Bengaluru for a helicopter ride to his next public meeting. Sporting a salt-and-pepper beard, the 60-year-old is the Congress's go-to man in a crisis. He has had an unbroken run as a seven-time MLA from the Sathanur and Kanakapura constituencies in Bangalore Rural. On what's unique about this assembly election, he observes, "All sections of the society in the state are agitating. The ruling BJP has never made any attempt to satisfy their needs. It came out with so many promises, but hasn't been able to deliver. The desertion of senior leaders like Jagadish Shettar and Laxman Savadi show that all is not well."

In allotting seats, the Vokkaliga belt in the south has been a priority for the BJP, while the Congress is eyeing the north where the Lingayats are in a majority

Those who know Shivakumar well say that he may have a reputation of being hustler and a bit brash but also exhibits tenacity and absolute loyalty to the party. Among the richest MLAs in Karnataka, with assets worth Rs 1,358 crore, he hails from the influential Vokkaliga community and is always game for a fight. Shivakumar played a key role in 'safeguarding' his party's MLAs during the scramble for power that resulted from a hung Karnataka assembly in May 2018. The previous year, he had famously helped the late Ahmed Patel secure his Rajya Sabha win in a similar fashion—this episode, Shivakumar claims, is why he faces a slew of income-tax evasion and money-laundering cases now. "Politics," he says, "is my passion—I eat, drink and talk politics. I believe in making history and leaving a legacy by changing the lives of people and doing something important for society." Is there a make-or-break issue for this election? Pat comes his reply, "There is no breaking for the Congress—we will make it." A flurry of party hangers-on greet him as he walks briskly towards the helicopter and asks his helper to pack his breakfast so that he can have it on board. Where Shivakumar is brimming with energy, Siddaramaiah exudes quiet confidence and sagacity. If Yediyurappa is the BJP's mascot, Siddaramaiah is the Congress's crowd-puller, the only Karnataka CM to finish a five-year term (2013-2018) since D. Devaraj Urs in 1978. Siddaramaiah has crafted his political image as a leader of the backward classes. His oratory is characterised by his rustic drawl and wit—on occasion, he can even shake a leg to a folk tune or two. Now, he is eyeing a second stint as CM. The Congress must tread carefully on the leadership issue because Shivakumar believes it is his turn now to get the top job if the party wins.

So far, both have kept their ambitions and tempers in control, with each acknowledging that the party MLAs should decide who the chief minister should be. Also, as a senior Congress leader pointed out, "If there is a façade of unity, it is because neither of them has the capacity to break away from the Congress and run a party on his own. Or wants to sabotage the party chances or use blackmail to get his way. Overall, the party is broadly united and is relatively a cohesive machine." The Congress, in fact, has a surfeit of leaders with chief ministerial potential, including the party's national president, the 80-year-old Mallikarjun Kharge, who comes